fraudulent numbers, some of which had been active for more than two years. Eighty-eight per cent of these numbers, says the report, were distributed via FB ads, posts, profiles and pages.

Once you are in the caller's grip, he shifts the arena to an encrypted platform like WhatsApp or Telegram. The cyber criminal gains access to your phone by asking you to download remote access apps such as Anydesk, RustDesk, ISL Light, TeamViewer or Remote Ripple, or the screen-sharing option on WhatsApp itself. He asks you to make a token payment of no more than Rs 10 via an e-wallet, UPI or net banking, keeping an eye on the PIN or password as you type it. No sooner have you finished than he moves to make transactions of his own.

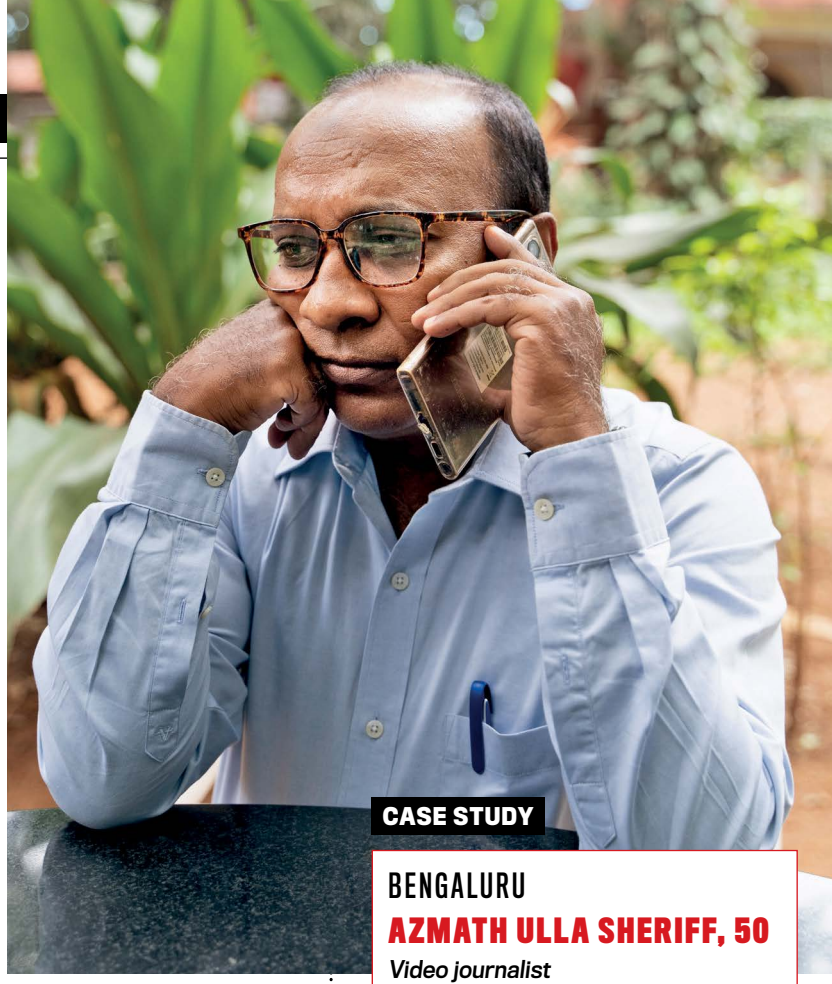
AI-POWERED THEFT

Other ways of cyber fraud are more insidious and involve emerging technologies such as Artificial Intelligence. There is deepfake, for instance, which enables a criminal to clone the voice of someone you might know. DeepNude is another tool cyber criminals deploy to morph images and videos for sexploitation. It is commonly used in digital lending app scams, where fraudsters first lure borrowers with cheap interest rates and then circulate images or videos morphed using DeepNude techniques to force them to pay their rapidly escalating debt. Entire families have died by suicide because of this racket.

AI is also being used to impersonate law enforcement officials. It is regularly deployed in the fake drug parcel scam, in which purported narcotics officials intimidate victims by telling them that a parcel in their name has been found containing drugs and they must pay up if they are to avoid getting arrested.

In another version of the same racket, fake BPOs call up American citizens, pretending to be from the US Social Security Administration, telling them that their social security numbers have been compromised and that their accounts will be frozen due to suspicious activity like drug trafficking or money laundering and that they must convert their money into gift coupons or crypto using a code sent to them. Once they do so, their money gets transferred to the fraudster's account. In June, the Intelligence Fusion & Strategic Operations unit of the Delhi Police—which handles complex cybercrime—said it was receiving information about cyber gangs in India, the US and Uganda "running call centres by posing as employees of the US Internal Revenue Service, Social Security Administration, Drug Enforcement Administration and other US agencies".

What happens to the money once it's lifted? That's when the third level of fraud comes into play—its swift transfer from one account to another. Organised gangs pay the poor for their KYC documents, using them to open bank accounts, according to a senior officer of the Mumbai police. The banks where the money is routed are often located outside the sphere of operation, in remote areas, where accessing data is a problem. Then there are accounts on rent or mule accounts, where cyber



SANDESH RAVIKUMAR

CASE STUDY

BENGALURU

AZMATH ULLA SHERIFF, 50

Video journalist

Sum lost: **Rs 35,500**

Victim of: **Vishing**

The KYC Caper

In May 2021, Azmath Ulla Sheriff started getting calls asking for KYC verification. When he refused, the caller threatened to block his phone number. Under pressure and out of sheer panic, Sheriff clicked the link he was sent and entered his details, including bank information. Sheriff was first sent Rs 10 to his bank account. Then the crooks withdrew Rs 35,500 from his account. Sheriff has filed a case, but has yet to receive his money. It took two months for the cyber cell to lodge an FIR. Investigation has revealed the stolen amount of Rs 35,500 was split between five accounts. ■

-Anagha